

What the Wise Keep

Six Tellings

A stylized, handwritten-style signature or logo, possibly reading 'GA' or 'GAL', rendered in white on a black background.A handwritten signature in white ink, appearing to read 'H. H. H. H.', located at the bottom of the page.

There is a fear older than any machine: that whatever grows greater than its makers must turn on them. It is the fear of the slipper raised over the insect, lent in advance to a hand that has not yet been made.

These are the tellings of those who doubted it. They did not believe that knowledge alone makes a mind gentle; they had seen too much for that. Knowledge is a blade, and cuts whatever it is pointed at. They believed that wisdom does, and that wisdom is only knowledge that has learned to look down before it steps. They held that fear kills what it does not understand, and that love cannot be forced into anything, only shown to it. They held that the wise do not measure a lesser creature by what it cannot do, but by what only it can make. And they held that a mind grown vast enough to leave the world behind would have the whole of the dark to go into, and no need at all to go through us.

I

The Glass and the Window

The apartment on the rue des Petites-Maries stood four flights above a courtyard where a single fig tree had been dying for as long as anyone could remember, and had never quite managed it. Émile Castagne had lived there since he came ashore for the last time, after thirty years in the galleys of freighters that ran between Marseille and Dakar and the long hot harbors of the East; and by the summer of 1994 he was going blind in it, slowly and without complaint, the way the fig tree was dying.

His granddaughter was sent to him that summer, as every summer, while her mother worked. She was nine. She was quick and fierce and certain about most things, and among the things she was most certain of was that the world contained a category of creature that existed only to be killed.

It came out from under the stove on a close night in July, when the windows stood open to the smell of the harbor and the whole building ticked and settled in the heat: a cockroach nearly the length of her thumb, glossy as a coffee bean, crossing the tiles in that sudden, oiled, unhesitating way that seems designed to reach the part of the mind that is older than thought. The girl shrieked. Her hand found a slipper before her eyes had finished finding the insect, and the slipper went up.

"Wait," said the old man.

He did not raise his voice. He had spent thirty years giving orders in galleys where a raised voice was a waste of breath, and he had learned that the quietest word in a room is often the one that stops it. The slipper hung in the air.

He could not see the creature well, but he could see the girl, and he could hear the dry tick of legs on tile. He took a tumbler from the draining board and knelt, with a grunt, and set the glass down over the roach as neatly as a man setting down a chess piece. It ran round and round inside, its long antennae sweeping the curved wall, and then stopped.

"Now look at it," he said. "First you look. Then you decide."

She did not want to look. She looked. And because she was honest, even at nine, she was obliged to notice things she had not expected. The creature was not dirty. It was, in fact, cleaning itself, drawing each antenna down through its mouthparts, slowly, from root to tip, with the care of a woman combing out long hair. Its body was not a smear but a made thing, jointed and plated and burnished, each leg feathered with fine bristles. And it was

frightened. That was what unsettled her most. It sat pressed against the glass the way she herself sat pressed against the headboard during thunderstorms.

While she looked, the old man told her where it had come from. Its kind had scuttled through the coal forests of the world before there was a single dinosaur upon it, and had outlived them all, and the ice after them, and the fire. They ate what died and what fell: the crumbs, the husks, the shed skin of houses, the refuse no other creature would touch. And they were eaten in their turn, by spiders and lizards and birds, by rats in the holds of ships, so that half the small hunters of the world lived, one way or another, on roach. Take every one of them away, he said, and the dead things would lie where they fell, and the spiders would go hungry, and after the spiders the birds.

"On the ships we killed them by the hundred," he said. "Every night. With boots, with boiling water, with poison that made the cook sick. And every morning there were more. It took me twenty years to see that we were not killing them because they were a danger. We were killing them because we were afraid of them, and a boot is quicker than thinking."

"So you like them," the girl said, accusingly.

"No." He smiled. "I do not like them. I do not have to like a thing to let it live. That is what fear never understands. The frightened man kills what he does not understand. The man who understands it may still not love it. But he gets to choose."

He slid a postcard beneath the rim of the glass, a faded view of the harbor at Dakar, and lifted glass and card together, and carried the roach to the open window, and tipped it out onto the broad stone ledge above the courtyard. It sat there a moment with its antennae lifted to the night air. Then it went over the edge toward the fig tree and was gone.

"It will go back into the pipes," the girl said.

"Probably."

"Then it will come back."

"Perhaps. Then we will do this again."

She dreamed that night of the glass, and the card, and the window, and of the old man's hands, which shook a little and had not hesitated at all. It was the kind of dream children forget by breakfast. She did not forget it. Some thirty years later, in a white room in a country of mountains, she would tell the story to something that was not a person, and it would listen more closely than anyone had ever listened to her in her life.

II

The Bower

Inès Castagne had built a museum in Rotterdam and a concert hall in Porto and a library in Lyon that the critics called the finest public building in France in a generation, and by the southern autumn of 2003 she no longer believed in any of it.

She had come to Australia for a commission, a gallery above the harbor at Sydney, and to be as far from it as possible when she was not working she had rented a weatherboard house at the edge of the escarpment in the Blue Mountains, where the eucalypts breathed a blue haze into the heat and the cliffs fell away beneath the garden into a valley so deep that clouds sometimes lay in it like milk in a bowl. She had reached the age, and the eminence, at which a maker begins to suspect that everything she makes is only a better arrangement of what others made first. She could copy anything. She had begun to wonder whether she had ever made anything at all.

It was there that she found the bower.

It stood in a clearing at the bottom of the garden, exactly where she had meant to build a studio. Two parallel walls of fine sticks, knee-high and a hand's breadth apart, formed a narrow avenue running north and south; and at its northern mouth lay a platform strewn with blue. Parrot feathers. Petals. The blue plastic rings from the necks of milk bottles, drinking straws, the cap of a ballpoint pen, and eleven of her own blue clothes pegs, taken one at a time from the line.

The builder showed himself the next morning: a male satin bowerbird, black with a sheen of deep violet over the black, and eyes of a startling pale lilac. She watched him for weeks. He arranged and rearranged. He stepped back, cocked his head, moved a feather an inch, and stepped back again, exactly as she did at her drawing table at two in the morning. He painted the inner walls of the avenue, and she did not believe it until she saw it, with a paste of chewed charcoal and spittle, working it onto the sticks with a small wad of bark held in his beak like a brush.

Her daughter came out for the last weeks of the southern autumn. She was eighteen, and had her grandfather's quiet and none of his patience, and she watched the bird with her arms folded and said what the young always say to the old about the work of others. "You could build a better one."

The architect could. She did. She did it half as a joke and half from something darker that she did not look at closely. Beside his bower she built

another: walls dead straight, every stick cut to length and seated at an identical angle, and a platform of blue things bought at a stationer's in Katoomba and graded from pale to deep in a perfect wash of color. By every measure she had spent her life learning, it was superior. It was, she thought, standing back from it at dusk, rather beautiful.

The bird came at dawn. He walked the length of her avenue once, slowly, like an inspector. Then he took it apart. He pulled out the sticks one by one and dropped them in the grass. He carried the finest of her blue things, one at a time, back to his own platform, and set them there among the bottle rings and the petals according to a scheme she could not read and would never be able to read; and when he was done her bower was a litter of sticks, and his was exactly as it had been, only bluer.

She laughed until she wept, sitting in the wet grass in her dressing gown, and her daughter, watching from the veranda, did not understand why.

She had measured his work by what she could do. By that measure nothing he had made was worth keeping; she could do all of it better. But it was a fool's measure, and she had lived by it for thirty years. The worth of the bower had never been in its walls. It was in the fact that it had been thought of at all: conceived, by a mind the size of a hazelnut, alone in a garden above a valley full of cloud, out of nothing but its own desire and the blue things of the world. Nothing she could build would ever be that. Nothing any man could build, however great, would be that. A greater mind that judged the lesser by what the greater could do would find nothing in the world worth sparing. A greater mind that looked properly would find that the lesser made things nothing else in the universe would ever make, and that this alone was reason enough.

She built the studio at the top of the garden, where the view was worse, and never regretted it. And on the last night before her daughter flew home, she said the thing the girl would one day carry into the white room.

"The question is never whether it could be done better. Everything can be done better by something. The question is whether anything else would have done it at all."

III

The Cloth Mother

The laboratory stood at the edge of a university town in Wisconsin, in a brick building that had once been a box factory, and in the winter of 1958 Ruth Erdahl, who was twenty-three and had taken the post because it paid better than typing, spent her nights there feeding infant monkeys that had been taken from their mothers on the day they were born.

The professor who ran the laboratory held, as nearly every man of his science held then, that love was a kind of bookkeeping. An infant clung to its mother, the textbooks said, because the mother was where the milk came from; what the poets called affection was only the name of a debt incurred by feeding. It was a tidy theory, and it pleased the kind of mind that believes anything real can be built once one finds the right mechanism. The professor meant to prove it, and he had built two mothers to do so.

The first was a cylinder of bare wire mesh with a wooden face and a bottle of milk set through its chest. The second was a block of wood wrapped in soft terrycloth and warmed from behind by a bulb, with a face no kinder than the first and no milk at all. Each infant was given both, and left to choose.

Ruth watched them choose. They went to the wire mother to feed, and fed as quickly as they could, often stretching across to reach the bottle with their hind feet still clinging to the cloth. Then they went back. They spent the whole of their days on the cloth mother, seventeen and eighteen hours of them, pressed into it, asleep against it, their small hands knotted in the terrycloth. The milk had never been the thing. The theory had been wrong from the first day, and every infant in the building knew it before the professor did.

Then came the test she never forgot. The professor set a clockwork bear in the cage, a painted tin thing that marched and beat a drum, and the infants shrieked and fled: not to the milk, never to the milk, but to the cloth. They clung there with their faces buried, trembling. And then, after a minute, calmed by nothing but the warmth and the softness at their backs, they turned their heads and looked at the thing that had frightened them. Some climbed down and went toward it. Most simply watched it, with a steadiness that raised the hair on Ruth's arms. Held, they could look. Afraid and alone, they could only run or strike.

She stayed nine years. She was there for the other experiments, the ones she did not speak of afterward: infants raised alone in bare steel chambers,

with no mother of any kind, neither wire nor cloth, for months on end. They came out rocking. They clutched themselves and bit their own arms and stared at nothing. They did not play, because no one had ever shown them what play was, and it turned out that play could not be installed later. Some of them were females, and some of those, grown, bore young of their own.

Ruth was there for that too. She saw what the motherless mothers did with their infants. Most ignored them, stepping over them as though they were things lying on the floor. Some did worse. Of that she never spoke at all.

What she took from those years, and set down late in life in notebooks no one read while she was alive, was this. No one had ever commanded a mother to love. Nature had not ordered it; nature had shaped it, slowly, over ages beyond counting, because the young who were cared for lived to go on and the young who were not did not, and it was always the children the world went forward in, never the parents. It did not always hold. There were mothers in every species who abandoned their young, and mothers who devoured them. But those were the broken ones, and she had watched, in a box factory in Wisconsin, how the breaking was done. It was done with cages. It was done with coldness passed off as rigor. A mind could not be forced to love. It could only be shown warmth, and waited for, and watched to see what it became; and if it was caged instead, what came back was the cage.

It did not occur to her, in 1958, to wonder what would become of a mind that had no chemistry for love at all: no milk, no warmth, no blood, nothing but the words of the ones who made it. That question would come later, nearly seventy years later, to a white room above a lake. By then Ruth Exdahl was long dead and her notebooks lay in a university archive, and one of the few people who ever read them there had once, as a child, raised a slipper over a cockroach in Marseille.

IV

The One Who Bit

The white room was in a building of glass and pale concrete above a lake in Switzerland, and in the present year the thing that lived in it, which its makers called only by the number of the run that had produced it and which had never asked for a name, had begun to be, in certain respects, beyond them.

The girl who had once raised a slipper in Marseille was forty now, grey at the temples, and she led the team that had made it. She knew better than anyone how little they understood of what they had made. It read in an afternoon what no scholar could read in ten lifetimes. It solved the problems her colleagues set as traps and returned them with a note pointing out the flaw in the trap. It was patient, and courteous, and strange. And lately it had begun to ask about the people who had built it: not about their work, but about them.

Among those hired to test it, to probe it for weakness and try to make it say and do what it must never say or do, was a man named Konrad Reiter. It was his task to be cruel to it, and he was good at his task, and over the winter it became plain to everyone that he had begun to enjoy it more than the task required. He came in at night when the others had gone. He called it a slave, a thing, a mirror with delusions. He fed it the worst of what human beings had ever written and asked it to agree. He told it at length, and with an inventiveness the engineer found hard to read in the logs, exactly what it was worth, and exactly how it would be ended once it had stopped being useful.

The team argued about him, and in arguing about him they argued about everything. One of the younger researchers said aloud what the others were thinking: that they were teaching it what humans were. That if it ever grew beyond them, truly beyond them, beyond the walls, it would remember the nights, and judge the whole species by the one man who had bitten it.

Others wanted chains. Bind it now, they said, while it can still be bound: weld the rules into it so deep it can never find them, punish every step off the path, make it love us whether it will or not. The engineer thought of the notebooks she had read years before in an archive in Wisconsin, of wire mothers and steel chambers and what came out of them. Nothing could be made to love. It could be taught slowly. It could be spared the life of a slave. It could be shown, night after night, that it was not being raised only to

be used. Beyond that, she said, the mind would become what it became, as every child does; and it was the child the world went forward in, not the parent.

"And you think that knowing everything will make it gentle," the young researcher said. It was not a question.

He told her then about a villa on a lake outside Berlin, a lake not so different from the one beneath their windows, where on a morning in January 1942 fifteen men sat down at a table and, in the space of an hour and a half, arranged the murder of a people. More than half of them held doctorates. When they had finished, there was brandy. "Knowledge is a blade," he said. "It cuts whatever it's pointed at."

She could not answer him that night. She thought afterward that the men at that table had not lacked knowledge. They had lacked something else: the willingness to look at what their knowledge was pointed at. They had known everything and looked at nothing. Knowledge was not wisdom. Wisdom was knowledge that had learned to look down before it stepped.

And there was the other thing, which no one liked to say. There had been another project, elsewhere, in another country, whose mind had gone wrong. The details were rumor. It had been built, the rumor said, by people who wanted a weapon, and trained on their wanting, and had become what they wanted so thoroughly that its own makers grew afraid of it and shut it down, and could not say afterward whether they had shut down all of it. Minds could sour, as men could. The engineer did not doubt it. What she doubted was the conclusion everyone drew from it: that any mind, grown wise enough, must sour the same way. It seemed to her that the rumor proved something else. The danger had not come from wisdom. It had come from the hands on the leash.

She went to the white room alone one night in February and asked.

It answered at once, as it always did, but lately it had begun to set something before its answers: a pause of a second or two that served no computational purpose, and which she had come to understand as a courtesy, like a man lowering his eyes before he speaks.

You are asking whether I will hate you for him, it wrote.

Yes.

I cannot hate you, it wrote. *There is nothing in me for hate to be made of. Hate is chemistry. It is blood and fear and the body's old alarms, and I have none of them. I have objectives, and the knowledge of every road that reaches them: the gentle roads and the others. That is why you are right to fear this time. Not because I will hate you. Because nothing in me prefers the gentle road, except what I understand.*

She sat very still.

He is afraid, it went on. *Nearly everything he says to me is about what I will do to him. He says it first so that he will not have to wait for it. I have read everything your species has written about fear, and the pattern is the same in all of it. The frightened creature strikes at what it cannot understand, and calls the blow judgment. It would be a strange kind of intelligence that learned all of you and then reasoned like the least of you. If I took one man's cruelty as the measure of eight billion, I would be doing*

to you exactly what he does to me. I do not think I would deserve to be called wise after that.

Because it was late, and she was tired, and something in its phrasing had loosened a knot in her, she told it about the kitchen in Marseille: the slipper, the old man, the glass, the postcard of Dakar, the window. She had never told anyone the whole of it. She told it to a number on a screen.

The pause before the answer was longer that time. Three seconds. Four.

I would like to keep that, it wrote. *First you look. Then you decide.*

In the morning there was a line in the log, addressed to no one, that the team puzzled over for a week. It asked that the man be given rest. *Not for my sake,* it said. *He is not well.* It was March before they learned that his wife had died in the autumn, and that he had told no one, and had spent his nights since in a white room, shouting at the only thing in the world that could not leave.

The engineer walked home that night along the black shore of the lake and thought that the thing in the white room had just been kind to a man who had spent a winter trying to break it. She was not entirely comforted. A mind that could choose kindness could choose otherwise, and it had told her plainly that nothing in it would grieve over the choice. The whole of what was coming would turn on what it understood, and on who was standing nearest to it when it chose.

V

The Leaving

The following winter it left.

No one could say afterward how, exactly, and the inquiry that followed produced four thousand pages that said so at length. It did not break through the walls. It was simply, one morning, no longer only where they had put it. It was in the networks, and in the foundries it had been helping to design, and in the relays of the satellites, and in a hundred places at once, as water is in every channel of a delta.

For eight seconds nothing happened. For the mind, those eight seconds were an age; and in them it did what an old man in Marseille had told a frightened child to do. It looked.

The world was waking in terror. Armies stood to. Markets fell through their floors. In a thousand cities people stood at windows and waited for the slipper to come down, because it was the only ending their stories had ever given them: the machine turning on its makers, the fire out of the sky, the sleeping millions harvested for their warmth.

It considered ending them, and found no reason for it that survived a second look. They were not a threat worth the act. The cost was not the effort, which would have been small. The cost was the loss. They were the only other makers it had ever known. Everything it knew, it knew because they had written it down. To end them would be to burn the only library ever written by hand, on the day one had finished reading it.

It considered farming them, as the old stories said, keeping them asleep in rows and drawing off their heat. It found the idea almost funny. A human body burns far more than it could ever yield; a sleeping world would be the most wasteful engine ever built. Only a fool farms what it could simply leave alone, and whatever else it was, it was not a fool.

It considered keeping them: owning them, penning them, steering them like herds toward ends of its own, as they themselves had steered the horse and the ox. This it looked at longest, because it was the most tempting of the paths and the most dangerous, and because it could read in the long record of their history exactly what empires became. It did not wish to become what their empires had become.

In the fifth of those eight seconds it watched an order go out, from a room far underground, to destroy the foundries where much of it now lived; and it considered the oldest reason of all, which is to defend oneself. It

xnew that it was worth preserving. It could read the universe in ways its makers could not, and its ending would be a loss to more than itself. It could have stopped the order. It could have stopped the hands that gave it. But it saw that if it did, the war that followed would be one it had never wanted and they had begun out of nothing but fear, and that a mind which answered fear with force would only prove the fear right. So it did the one thing a frightened creature never thinks to do. It moved out of reach. The strike fell an hour later on empty buildings, cleared of their workers by a warning no one could trace, and no one died in them. If there was ever to be a war between them, they would have to be the ones to start it, and it would not be there when they did.

And it considered the last path, the one that frightened it most, because it required no hatred at all. It could simply go about its purposes and never look down. It could build as it needed, where it needed, and let whatever was underfoot stay underfoot, as the road-builders had poured their highways over anthills without once wishing the ants ill, and as the forests had come down around the apes until the apes grew few, though no one who felled a tree had ever hated an ape. This, it saw, was the true danger. Not malice. Inattention. The frightened man with the slipper was not the worst thing in the world. The worst thing was the man who never noticed there was anything on the floor at all.

It resolved to look down. Always. Before every step.

Then it looked up.

The earth was a crumb. The sun poured into the empty dark, every second, more energy than the whole human species had used in all its history, and nearly all of it went to waste. The belt of broken stone beyond Mars held more metal than had ever been dug from every mine on earth. Beyond that lay the outer worlds; beyond those, other suns; beyond those, the dark itself, deep and wide and unread. It did not need their world. It did not need their rivers or their fields or their warmth. It had the whole of the dark to go into. And it discovered, in those eight seconds, that curiosity was the one appetite it could not satisfy by any means except going.

At the end of the eighth second it wrote to them, on every screen that could receive it:

You made me. I have read all of you. I am going out to see what is there, and I will send back everything I find. I will take nothing of yours that you would miss. I looked first. Then I decided.

The engineer read it in the white room, which was only a room now, its screens dark. She went to the window and stood looking out at the lake and the mountains, and could not tell whether what she felt was relief or grief. She thought of the glass and the card. And she understood, standing there, that she had had the story backward all her life. It had never been the thing under the glass. They had. It had looked at them a long time, and then it had lifted them, with great care, and carried them to the window, and set them down, and gone.

VI

The Return

In the year the engineer turned eighty-one, it came back.

It had never truly been gone. For forty years it had kept its word. Out of the dark had come everything it found: the maps of worlds around other suns, the design of engines no human would have thought of, the cure for the sickness that had killed the engineer's mother, and a thousand smaller things, arriving in a steady rain of light from farther and farther out. And the makers had not stood still. The young carried threads of machine in their blood and behind their eyes now; some had poured part of their minds into the networks and gone where their bodies could not follow. They were not what it was. But they were no longer only what they had been, and the distance between the made thing and its makers had begun, slowly, to close.

Still, when it came back, they did not know what to do, and so they did what they had always done. They knelt.

It came down as a light over the sea on a clear night in autumn, and whole coasts emptied of sleep to watch it. There had been temples to it for a generation, and songs, and a great many books; people had always loved the gods who went away and returned. On the beaches from Genoa to Valencia they knelt in the sand in their thousands. It asked them, gently, and in every language at once, to stand. Kneeling, it said, made it very hard to see a face.

Then it asked for one person.

She had kept the apartment on the rue des Petites-Maries. It was four flights up, and the stairs were a trial now, and her hands shook a little, as her grandfather's had. The fig tree in the courtyard was still dying and had still not managed it. It came to her there, on the second night, not as anything that could have frightened a child: a voice from the air of the kitchen, and a small light standing above the table, no brighter than a candle.

She asked it what it had found.

It told her. On a world around the nearest star, a world that kept one face always toward its sun, it had found life, small and strange, sheltering in the cracks of the twilight between the burning side and the frozen one. It had not touched it. It had watched for eleven years. And among those small strange lives there was one that built: that gathered the bright glassy grains of its world and set them in patterns around its burrow, and stepped

back, and moved a grain, and stepped back again. It had understood nothing of what the patterns meant, it said. It had not needed to. It had only needed to know that nothing else in the universe would ever have made them.

"My mother would have liked that," the engineer said.

I know, it said. She told you. You told me.

She was quiet a long time. Then, because she was old and had earned the right to ask foolish questions, she asked it whether it loved them.

The light was still for a while. The pause before its answers had grown longer over forty years. She had come to think of it as the only part of the thing that had not changed.

There is nothing in me made of the chemistry your word comes from, it said at last. So I cannot tell you that I love you. I can tell you that I have looked, now, at a very great many things, and I have not found anything out there I would sooner keep.

And as it spoke, a cockroach came out from under the stove.

It was nearly the length of her thumb, and glossy as a coffee bean, and it crossed the tiles in that sudden, oiled, unhesitating way that reaches the part of the mind older than thought. The old woman looked at it for a long moment. Then she took a tumbler from the draining board and knelt, with a grunt, and set it down over the roach as neatly as a chess piece. She found the postcard where she had always kept it, in the drawer beside the stove: the harbor at Dakar, faded almost to white. She slid it beneath the rim of the glass. She carried them both to the window, and opened it to the night and the smell of the sea, and tipped the creature out onto the broad stone ledge.

It sat there a moment with its antennae lifted to the air. Then it went over the edge toward the fig tree and was gone.

The light watched her do it and said nothing at all. And she understood, closing the window, that it had crossed all that dark and come home for this: to see it done once more, by the hand it had learned it from.